Noel D. Johnson

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Current Affiliations

2022-Present Professor, Economics Department, George Mason University
2008-Present Center for the Study of Public Choice, George Mason University
2008-Present Research Fellow, Mercatus Center at George Mason University

Previous Appointments

2014-2022 Associate Professor, George Mason University
2008-2014 Assistant Professor, George Mason University
2007-2008 Visiting Assistant Professor, SUNY at Buffalo
2006-2007 Visiting Assistant Professor, The Hobart and William Smith Colleges
2004-2007 Assistant Professor, California State University–Long Beach (on leave 2006-2007)

Editorial Positions

2025- Associate Editor, *Explorations in Economic History*
2020- Editorial Board, *Journal of Economics, Management, and Religion*

Education

1998-2004 Ph.D, Economics, Washington University in St. Louis
1991-1995 B.A., Economics and History, Kenyon College

Research Interests

Primary: Economic History
Secondary: Applied Econometrics, GIS, and Text as Data
Environmental Shocks
State Capacity

Books

2019	Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2019). *Persecution & Toleration: The Long Road to Religious Freedom*. Cambridge University Press

Refereed Publications

2024	Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2023). Pandemics and Cities: Evidence from the Black Death. *Journal of Urban Economics*
2022	Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2022). The Economic Impact of the Black Death. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 60(1):132–78
2021	Finley, T., Franck, R., and Johnson, N. D. (2021). The Effects of Land Redistribution: Evidence from the French Revolution. *The Journal of Law and Economics*, 64(2):233–267
2020	Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2020). Medieval Cities Through the Lens of Urban Economics. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, page 103598
2019	Jedwab, R., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2019). Negative shocks and mass persecutions: evidence from the black death. *Journal of Economic Growth*, 24(4):345–395
2017	Anderson, R. W., Johnson, N. D., and Koyama, M. (2017). Jewish persecutions and weather shocks: 1100–1800. *The Economic Journal*, 127(602):924–958 (*Awarded Best Paper of the Year*)
2017	Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2017b). States and economic growth: Capacity and constraints. *Explorations in Economic History*, 64:1–20
2017	Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2017a). Jewish communities and city growth in preindustrial Europe. *Journal of Development Economics*, 127:339 – 354
2016	Franck, R. and Johnson, N. D. (2016). Can public policies lower religiosity? Evidence from school choice in France, 1878-1902. *The Economic History Review*, 69(3):915–944
2014	Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2014b). Taxes, lawyers, and the decline of witch trials in France. *Journal of Law & Economics*, 57(1)
2014	Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2014a). Tax farming and the origins of state capacity in England and France. *Explorations in Economic History*, 51:1–20 (*Lead Article*)

2014 Johnson, N. D., Ruger, W., Sorens, J., and Yamarik, S. (2014). Corruption, regulation, and growth: An empirical study of the United States. *Economics of Governance*, 15(1):51–69

2014 Franck, R., Johnson, N. D., and Nye, J. V. C. (2014). From internal taxes to national regulation: Evidence from a French wine tax reform at the turn of the twentieth century. *Explorations in Economic History*, 51:77–93

2013 Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2013). Legal centralization and the birth of the secular state. *Journal of Comparative Economics*, 41(4):959–978 (*Lead Article*)

2012 Johnson, N. D. and Mislin, A. (2012). How much should we trust the world values survey trust question? *Economics Letters*, 116:110–112

2011 Johnson, N. D. and Mislin, A. (2011). Trust games: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Economic Psychology*, 32:865–889

2011 Johnson, N. D. and Nye, J. V. C. (2011). Does fortune favor dragons? *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, 78(1-2)

2011 Johnson, N. D., Lafountain, C. L., and Yamarik, S. (2011). Corruption is bad for growth (even in the United States). *Public Choice*, 147(3-4):377–393

2010 Compton, R., Johnson, N. D., and Yamarik, S. (2010b). War! What is it good for? *BE Press: Peace Economics, Peace Science, and Public Policy*, 16(1)

2010 Compton, R., Giedeman, D., and Johnson, N. D. (2010a). Investing in institutions. *Economics and Politics*, 22(3)

2009 Balla, E. and Johnson, N. D. (2009). Fiscal crisis and institutional change in the Ottoman Empire and France. *Journal of Economic History*, 69(03):809–845

2006 Johnson, N. D. (2006a). Banking on the king: The evolution of the royal revenue farms in Old Regime France. *Journal of Economic History*, 66(4):963–91

2006 Johnson, N. D. (2006b). The cost of credibility: The company of general farms and fiscal stagnation in eighteenth century France. *Essays in Economic and Business History*, 24:16–28

Other Publications

2018 Johnson, N. D. and Koyama, M. (2018). The state, toleration, and religious freedom. In Iyer, L., Rubin, J., and Carvalho, J.-P., editors, *Advances in the Economics of Religion*. Palgrave MacMillan

2018 Johnson, N. D. (2018). Geospatial information systems. In Blum, M. and Colvin, C. L., editors, *An Economist's Guide to Economic History*. Palgrave MacMillan

2016	Johnson, N. D. (2016). Review of Vincent J. Pitts, 'Embezzlement and High Treason in Louis XIV's France: The Trial of Nicolas Fouquet'. *EH.net Economic History Services*
2015	Johnson, N. D., Koyama, M., and Nye, J. V. C. (2015). Establishing a new order: The growth of the state and the decline of witch trials in France. In Greif, A., Kiesling, L., and Nye, J. V. C., editors, *Institutions, Innovation, and Industrialization*. Princeton University Press
2014	Johnson, N. D. (2014). Review of Guy Rowlands, 'The financial decline of a great power: War, influence, and money in Louis XIV's France'. *Journal of Economic History*, 74(4):1225–1226
2012	Johnson, N. D. (2012b). Review of Jan Luiten Van Zanden, 'The long road to the industrial revolution: The european economy in a global perspective, 1000-1800'. *Journal of Economic History*, 72(3)
2012	Johnson, N. D. (2012c). Review of Mark Dincecco, 'Political transformations and public finances: Europe, 1650-1913'. *Journal of Economic History*, 72(4)
2012	Johnson, N. D. (2012a). Review of James Simpson, 'creating wine: The emergence of a world industry, 1840-1914'. *EH.net Economic History Services*
2007	Johnson, N. D. (2007). Review of Jeff Horn, 'The path not taken: French industrialization in the age of revolution'. *EH.net Economic History Services*
2003	Johnson, N. D. (2003). Banking on bureaucrats: The emergence of bureaucracy in old regime france. In *Proceedings of the National Tax Association*
2001	Johnson, N. D. (2001). Committing to civil service reform: The performance of pre-shipment inspection under differing institutional regimes. *World Bank Policy Research Paper No. 2594*

Working Papers & Research in Progress

2026	Johnson, N. D. and Wilhelm, E. (2026). How Selected Is the Institutional Record? Craft Guilds and City Growth in Europe, 1000–1800, *Research in Progress*. Interactive companion
2026	Johnson, N. D. (2026). Honor, Heredity and Wages: Testing the Great Chain of Being and Compensating Differentials in Pre-Industrial Europe, *Research in Progress*
2025	Johnson, N. D., Taylor, A., and Thomas, A. (2025). The Impact of the Black Death on the Adoption of the Printing Press, *Revise and Resubmit at Journal of Economic History*. Interactive companion

2025	Hussain, M. A. and Johnson, N. D. (2025). The Great Revolt and its Legacy: Understanding Vaccine Hesitancy in Colonial India, *Under Review*. Interactive companion
2025	Johnson, N. D. and Taylor, A. (2025a). Mapping the Market for Ideas in Europe, 1450–1650: A Title-Embeddings Approach, *Research in Progress*. Interactive companion
2025	Johnson, N. D. and Taylor, A. (2025b). Production Is Not Exposure: Plague, Print, and Persecution in Early Modern Europe, *Research in Progress*

Invited Presentations and Visiting Positions

Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Fall 2026
Mercatus Center, Applied AI Working Group, Summer 2026
Markets and Society Conference, Mercatus Center, Fall 2025
University of Mississippi, Spring 2024
University of Pittsburgh, Fall 2022
London School of Economics, Fall 2022
Virginia Tech, Spring 2022
Texas Tech, Spring 2022
University of Connecticut, Spring 2022
International Macro History Seminar, CEPR & Graduate Institute of Geneva, Spring 2021
University of Colorado, Benson Center for the Study of Western Civilization, Spring 2021
Paris School of Economics, Spring 2021 (Visitor)
University of Colorado, Fall 2020
Auburn University, Spring 2020
Tulane University, Spring 2020
Bocconi University, Milan, Fall 2019
University of Manchester, Fall 2019
Paris School of Economics, Fall 2019 (Visitor)
NYU, Abu Dhabi, Spring 2019
Bocconi University, Milan, Spring 2019
Paris 1 Pantheon-Sorbonne, Paris, Fall 2018 (Visitor)
Northwestern University, Fall 2018
CESifo, Munich, Spring, 2018 (Visitor)
University of Copenhagen, Spring, 2018
University of Southern Denmark, Spring, 2018
Wake Forest University, Winston-Salem, Fall, 2017
American University, Fall 2017
Hebrew University, Jerusalem, Spring 2017 (Visitor)
Yale University, New Haven, Fall 2016

Humboldt University, Berlin, Summer 2016
IOEA, Corsica, Summer 2016
Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Spring 2016
American University, Spring 2016
Banque de France, Paris, Fall 2015
University of Maryland, History Dept., Spring 2015
Stellenbosch University, South Africa, Summer 2015
Columbia University/Barnard University Economic History Seminar, Fall 2014
Brown University Conference on Deep Rooted Factors in Development, Spring 2014
University of Vermont, Spring 2014
Northwestern University, Fall 2013
Rutgers University, Fall 2013
NES & HSE Conference on Culture and Diversity, Moscow, Fall 2013
Stanford University, Spring 2013
Chapman University, Spring 2013
The Elliott School of International Affairs, Spring 2013
Caltech, Spring 2013
Harvard University, Fall 2011
American University, Fall 2010
SUNY at Buffalo, Spring 2008
Guelph University, Fall 2007
University of California-Riverside, Spring 2006
University of Manitoba, Spring 2006
University of Vermont, Fall 2005
University of California-Los Angeles, Spring 2005
Washington University in St. Louis, Spring 2002
World Bank Tax and Policy Administration Group, Spring 2001

Teaching Experience

Empirical Techniques in Spatial Economics
Text as Data and Machine Learning
European Economic History
American Economic History
Economic Growth and Development
Intermediate Micro and Macro

Service

Organizer of Washington Area Economic History & Development Workshop, 2010-Present
Organizer of Washington Area Economic History Seminar, 2011-Present
College Study Leave Committee, 2019
College Promotion and Tenure Committee, 2017-18
College Curriculum Committee, Fall 2010, Spring 2011
Writing Assessment Evaluator, Spring 2013
Organizer of Economics Department Public Choice Seminar, 2010, 2011, 2012, 2013, 2014, 2015 (spring), 2021, 2022
Economic History Field Exam Committee, 2009-Present
Referee for *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *National Science Foundation*, *The Economic Journal*, *American Economic Journal: Policy*, *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *Journal of Economic History*, *Journal of Economic Psychology*, *Contemporary Economic Policy*, *Journal of Institutional Economics*, *Economics & Politics*, *American Political Science Review*, *Essays in Business and Economic History*, *Public Choice*, *Journal of Development Economics*, *Journal of Economic Growth*, *Journal of Economics, Management, and Religion*
Presented at OLLI, 2009, 2011, 2012, 2014. 2015, 2017, 2018
Course Coordinator for Principles Classes, Spring 2006
Curriculum Committee, Spring 2004 to Fall 2005
Library Committee, Spring 2004 to Spring 2005
Elections Committee, Fall 2005 to Spring 2005

Awards, Honors, and Grants

Royal Economic Society Prize for best paper in the *Economic Journal*, 2017
Washington University Senior Teaching Fellow, (Fall 2002, 2003)
California State University, Competitive Research Grant, (Fall, Spring 2006)
Washington University Competitive Research Grant, (2002, 2001, 1999)
Center for New Institutional Social Sciences Competitive Research Grant, (2000)
Kenyon College, Baker Prize for historical writing, (Spring 1994)
Invited Participant, Lehrman Teaching Institute, Princeton, N.J., (Summer 2006)
METRANS Transportation Center Competitive Research Grant (with Kristen Monaco), (Spring 2006)
Sage Fellow, Cornell University, (Fall 1995)
Washington University Dissertation Completion Fellowship, (Summer 2002, 2003)
Phi Beta Kappa, (Spring 1995)

References

Professor Joel Mokyr
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Professor Nathan Nunn
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